

Memory and Games, 01/12/2025 (#261370)

Author(s)

This pre-registration is currently anonymous to enable blind peer-review.
It has 3 authors.

Pre-registered on:

2025/12/01 05:39 (PT)

1) Have any data been collected for this study already?

No, no data have been collected for this study yet.

2) What's the main question being asked or hypothesis being tested in this study?

We aim to shed light on two puzzles: first, the high generosity observed in experimental dictator games, and second, the variation in generosity with seemingly irrelevant aspects of the game, such as the provisional allocation of available resources and the framing. We want to test whether: 1) these seemingly irrelevant features of the game causally affect participants' "representations" of the game; and 2) if the variation in games' representations is correlated with the action in the games. Our main hypothesis is that representations that contain higher levels of social proximity induce more generous behavior.

3) Describe the key dependent variable(s) specifying how they will be measured.

There are two key dependent variables:

1) The allocation chosen by the decision-maker (or "dictator"), that is, the amount that dictators allocate to themselves; we care about measures of central tendency of these allocations (mean, median); the distribution of allocations; and, the share of allocations at salient values: 4, 6, 8, and 12 (out of a budget of 12).

2) Game representation categories: participants will be asked an open-ended question about what drove their allocation decision (we call this "Reasons"). The answers to this question will be classified into categories of Social Proximity categories, using LLMs. The classification is carried out by feeding the model the open-ended answer and asking it to look for a mention of the recipient and their social proximity to the decision-maker (e.g., stranger, peer, co-worker, friend). The classification will be validated using Research Assistants, who will use the same criteria used for LLMs to classify the text.

4) How many and which conditions will participants be assigned to?

We will manipulate three dimensions with a design that (as described below) will result in 8 conditions. The two dictator games for Manipulation 1 are adapted from Krupka and Weber (JEEA, 2013) and List (JPE, 2007). By "provisional allocation", we refer to the initial allocations to the dictator and the recipient.

Manipulation 1, Game:

-Dictator Game à la Krupka-Weber (KW) = provisional allocation 12-0, choice set 0-12

-Dictator Game à la List-Take (LT) = provisional allocation 8-4, choice set 0-12

Manipulation 2, Story (participants are asked to read and summarize a short text describing an allocation problem from a real-world context; this is meant to prompt memory of their experience outside of the laboratory):

-No Story.

-Story with allocation in workplace context (Bonus)

-Story with allocation in a charity context (Aid)

Manipulation 3: Game Frame

-Allocation Task (or dictator game): participants are asked to split a total endowment between themselves and another participant.

-Pricing Task (or market game): participants' decision is framed as a market interaction; other than players' labels and actions' labels, the game features the same players, actions, and outcomes as in the Allocation Task.

The design is factorial with respect to Manipulation 1 x Manipulation 2 (= 6 conditions), plus pricing-task versions of the two games from Manipulation 1 without stories. This results in 8 between-subjects conditions.

Additionally, we also collect a within-subjects sample. In all within-subject sessions, participants are not asked to read and summarize a text (No Story). In a first version of within-subject sessions, we fix the Game to KW, and we manipulate the Frame (Allocation Task versus Pricing Task). In a second version of within-subject sessions, we fix the game to LT, and we manipulate the Frame (Allocation Task versus Pricing Task). In a third version of within-subject sessions, we fix the Frame (Allocation Task), and we manipulate the Game (KW versus LT).

5) Specify exactly which analyses you will conduct to examine the main question/hypothesis.

Note: our sample for the between-subjects analyses will consist of the sum of (a) the between-subjects sample plus (b) the observations from the first condition seen by subjects in the within-subjects sample. As a robustness check, we will also carry out the between-subjects analyses using only the between-subjects sample.

i) Effect of manipulations on allocations: using regression analysis, we study the effect of manipulations (Game, Story, and Game Frame) and of the

order of manipulations (AllocationFirst or PricingFirst; KWFirst or LTFirst) on mean allocation.

ii) Effect of manipulations on representations: using regression analysis, we study the effect of manipulations (Game, Story, and Game Frame) and of the order of manipulations (AllocationFirst or PricingFirst; KWFirst or LTFirst) on representations of the game. We measure game representations as discussed in our answer to question 3 above.

(iii) Decomposition of effects: we decompose differences in mean allocations between conditions into two parts: a) one due to differences in the distribution of social proximity levels (representations) and one due to differences in allocation behavior conditional on each level of social proximity. This is done through a symmetrized (Shapley/Oaxaca-Blinder) decomposition, which averages the two possible paths (changing distributions first or conditional behavior first) to attribute the total difference fairly between the two components.

6) Describe exactly how outliers will be defined and handled, and your precise rule(s) for excluding observations.

All the surveys contain (i) an attention check and (ii) comprehension questions. Participants who fail the attention check or who fail twice to answer all the comprehension questions correctly will be screened out. Screened-out participants won't contribute to the total sample size.

7) How many observations will be collected or what will determine sample size? No need to justify decision, but be precise about exactly how the number will be determined.

We will collect 400 participants for each of the 8 between-subjects conditions, resulting in a total of 3200 between-subjects participants. Additionally, we will collect 600 participants for each of the three versions of the within-subjects experiment, resulting in a total of 1800 within-subjects participants.

The total sample amounts to 5000 participants.

8) Anything else you would like to pre-register? (e.g., secondary analyses, variables collected for exploratory purposes, unusual analyses planned?)

We will extend the analyses to specific allocation outcomes, focusing on the probability of salient allocations (4, 6, 8, and 12) and allocation distribution. A subsample of participants will be asked what situation or experience they find similar to hypothetical game outcomes (we call this "Hypothetical Allocations" or "HPs"). We will use answers to these questions to construct an alternative measure of participants' game representations. We will also classify "Reasons" and "HPs" through Moral Categories (e.g., generous, theft, equity) using the same approach used for Social Proximity.

In addition, we will collect demographics (Age, Gender, Employment Status, and Experience with Prolific) to study the heterogeneity of the main effects and test whether individuals from different demographic groups differ in how they represent the game.